

Bottoms up!

Regimes come and go, and with them follow buzzwords, campaigns and propaganda. There were the Five-Year Plans, and later, India Shining, India Inc, Incredible India, Brand India, and who knows how many others.

Though it may not be very apparent from my general cynicism, I'm actually quite an optimist. I genuinely want to believe all these schemes are all well intentioned and directed at the betterment of everyone – people like you and me.

The objectivist in me however, cannot help but try and dig deeper. Can this sort of top-down model to uplift a nation really work? What's missing? Why can't India be the nation that it should be?

The more I ponder the more I keep coming to just one answer – Technology.

Yes, yes, this is Digit and we are a technology magazine and you'd expect me to say something like that. But it's not an exaggeration. Allow me to present my rationale.

The transformative power of technology can be witnessed throughout history. Look at the Nordic region – Finland with its “right to the internet” or Sweden, which at one point was one of the poorest nations in Europe, now is consistently ranked one of the most technologically innovative countries in the world.

In India small beginnings of this technology seeding can be seen through e-governance initiatives, projects such as 100 Smart Cities, and now the Digital India initiative. We all know e-governance is much needed to curb corruption, frauds and scams. I remember talking to the Secretary of IT (Maharashtra) a while ago and he had described an interesting anecdote of how they were able to digitally cross reference two independent consumer databases – Aadhaar and Gas Connections – to catch fraudsters who claimed to be below the poverty line in one database and had multiple connections to their name in another!

There's a huge caveat to this success story though – a major variable in the scheme of things that everyone seems to have overlooked – people. Smart cities inhabited by dumb people won't really work. And overtly smart fraudsters like the ones chronicled above will certainly not augment collective progress.

The only way to make people the right kind of “smart” is by exposure to technology. Of late, the term empowerment has been bandied about so much that it seems to have lost its weight, though there are situations where it genuinely applies. I

have seen village folk in the very interiors of my state when I go hiking. Phones are being used for more than just playing Temple Run. Farmers are looking up commodity prices, getting weather updates and the likes. There's irrigation technology, electrification and a lot more springing up where previously there was nothing. Overall the divide between the urban youth and their country cousins seems to have gotten narrower – all thanks to tech. Technology affects culture and technology affects mentality (more often, for the better).

But to even get to that stage, there should be a huge push on an allied sector – education. And nothing other than the infusion of technology can help increase education's reach. We had done a huge story back in 2013 about how technology could transform education. How smart learning infrastructure could potentially bring the high quality urban teaching resources to the mofussil. It's only when the non-metro India (the *real* India some would say) gets access to the same level of education and technology would the mentality of a nation change towards the path of progress.

But that's what we need – it's something so obvious, it's almost a no-brainer – but it has nothing to do with what will be done. Why? If at all we have learnt anything from books such as 1984, or even George Carlin's thinly-veiled sermons disguised as standup, is that it's always beneficial for the ruling classes to keep the masses ignorant. Technology is the only thing that can change that. Why do you think hackers were looked at as such a threat right from the late '80s?

I'm not one to shun wisdom even if I see it at the most innocuous of places – random graffiti, fortune cookies or, god forbid, even WhatsApp forwards. Take for example this brilliant aphorism on the back of a truck that struck a chord somewhere. “Mera Bharat Mahaan” was proudly written in bold, but the sobering irony followed with “*Banana Hai*” written in a small font.

And how do we put this truck wisdom into use? Here's an unusual idea - how about we actually try to make these development schemes work? What excuse would policy makers have then?

What do you guys think, will it work? 




Siddharth Parwatay
Assistant Editor

siddharth.parwatay@digit.in

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facebook.com/staticsid | [@staticsid](https://twitter.com/staticsid) |
editor@digit.in